Click and Mortal

Recently, I've come to the conclusion that old-style business – for the most part – just doesn't get the whole net idea. As a prime case in point, we can look at the venerable Barnes and Noble Booksellers.

As one in my profession is often forced to do, I found myself in need of a manual not too long ago. This particular manual was required so that I could pass a test the Microsoft created (seemingly) to torture the hell out of every system administrator who would really love to get certified on their products.

A quick web-search and I found that I was in luck. Barnes and Noble carried the book in question, and claimed it was in stock. Not only that, but I could save ten bucks by buying the literature from them. So, off I went to the nearest Barnes and Noble store location to purchase my book – an so my decent into retail hell began.

First, there was the overwhelming complexity of the store in question. It takes up about one city block (that's roughly the area of a football field, or so it seems from the inside). Looking for a kiosk to lead me to my selection was of no help, they don't exist in the store. I was finally able to locate an employee who could directly to the book in question about ten minutes later. The web search for the same book on the BN.com site took all of thirty seconds.

After finding the book I went to the checkout counter and expected to pay the price that the website said I would. No such luck, the register rang it up full price. Questioning the register clerk was less than helpful. According to a store employee the stores won't honor prices from the website, they're two different companies as far as the stores are concerned.

Well, this chain will honor a competitor's coupon in many cases. So I approached the clerk with a logical argument that if the website was a different entity than the stores, then they're competitors of each other and the discount should be honored. Needless to say, the look the clerk shot me could have burned holes into my jacket and I walked out of there paying the full price for my book.

So, it would seem that businesses like Barnes and Noble really do need to gain a better grasp of how people shop in this new, new economy. The website has the same name as the store; and it's owned by the same people; and there's just no real difference between stock, availability, or any other major factor. How can they honestly expect us to understand that the site and the store don't have anything to do with each other?

If it looks like a duck, waddles like a duck, and quacks like a duck, then I'm going to expect to get a duck - even if I'm ordering from mallards.com instead of walking out into the marsh to grab one in person.

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